

A SAINT'S JOURNEY



1910: Born in Kudamaloor, Kottayam district, Kerala, to a lower middle-class family.

1928: Joins Franciscan Clarist Congregation (FCC) to become a nun and assumes the name Alphonsa of Immaculate Conception.

1930: Receives religious habit, the next stage in becoming a nun.

1932-33: Works as a primary schoolteacher as directed by the convent.

1935: Attached as novitiate with the FCC convent in Bharananganam.

1936: Makes final profession to become a full-fledged nun.

1946: Passes away after a prolonged illness.

1953: Vatican accepts her as Servant of God and initiates the process of canonisation.

1984: Pope John Paul II formally approves miracles ascribed to her and pronounces her as Venerable.

1986: Pope John Paul II beatifies her at Kottayam and declares her as Blessed.

2007: Pope Benedict XVI authorises her canonisation.

2008: Pope Benedict XVI declares her a Saint.

Kottayam where St. Alphonsa of Immaculate Conception lived and died, nun Grace Kalariparambil, 77, can barely hide her excitement. "I have a vivid image of Alphonsamma at her funeral which I witnessed as a nine-year-old. As there were not enough people, the nuns had to carry Alphonsa's body to the cemetery. After more than six decades, she is being celebrated all over the world and is being venerated by the Pope."

For others, like former star athlete Shiny Wilson, Alphonsa was more than an inspiration. "This is a great day in my life. She has been my guide and icon all these years," says Wilson, who was among the faithful that day at the little house where the saint was born at Kudamaloor. Wilson narrates how she had prayed to Alphonsamma before she flew to Jakarta to participate in the Asian Championship in

nal name was Annakkutty, and has kept a large personal collection of the various small gifts she received from her.

Alphonsa's canonisation has come after a gruelling 55-year-long procedure laid down by the Vatican. The process began seven years after her death following almost 20 years of various illnesses, physical and mental. The process was triggered when persons in Bharananganam and Kudamaloor began narrating stories of how praying to Alphonsamma helped heal illnesses. This led to the local diocese taking up the cause of her canonisation with the approval of the Vatican. The ensuing process included various investigations into her life and deeds. Reports running into 14,000 pages and testimonials of hundreds of witnesses were inspected, evidence for at least two major miracles—mandatory for canonisation—to have

PILGRIM'S PROGRESS: The faithful offer prayers at St. Alphonsa's tomb

SHANKAR



1985: "I donated the gold medal I won there in the 800 m to her museum in Bharananganam in gratitude," she reveals. The house, Alphonsa Bhavan, today is run by the FCC and protected as a monument. Theramma Joseph, 74, the saint's niece and the closest surviving relative who also was at the house, sounded equally elated. "I was too sick to go to the ceremony at the Vatican. I am happy to be alive when my kochamma (aunt) is elevated as saint," says Joseph, who was among the five relatives at Alphonsa's funeral in 1946. She has written a book on Alphonsa, whose origi-

nal name was Annakkutty, and has kept a large personal collection of the various small gifts she received from her. occurred through the nun's "intercession" was collected. After the first miracle was approved—healing a person's congenital physical deformity—Pope John Paul II beatified Alphonsa as Blessed during his trip to Kerala in 1985. Canonisation required another miracle to occur after the candidate was beatified. This came in 1999 when a local couple, Shaji and Lizie Ozhuthottiyil, reported to the bishop that their three-year-old son, Jinil, who was born with a crippling clubfoot, started walking normally after they prayed at Alphonsa's tomb. This also was subjected